Scratch and Dent Dreams

By Eric Darby

INTRODUCTION

"Step right up, step right up! You won't believe your eyes. Step right up and see the amazing half man, half clam . . . . Carnival Barkers have gotten a bad rap over the years as "huxters" and slick-talking con men . . . But what if the "barking" was legitimate . . . what if the "sales pitch" was designed to encourage rather than mislead.

Step right up, step right up! You have the power to take things into your own hands, create your own solution, do not sit idly by hoping someone or something will come along and fix your situation. No more excuses, procrastination, self-pity, negativity, or self-doubt. Replace any sentence you ever started with "I can't because" with "I can because."

What if your "pitchman" had the answers? Scratch and Dent Dreams by Eric Darby.

Come on in, I've got a sale
on scratch and dent dreams,
whole cases of imperfect ambitions
stuff the idealists couldn't sell.
Yeah, I know none of its got price tags,

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you decide how much it's worth.
And none of its got glossy colored packaging
but it all works just fine.
I've got rainy day swing sets
good night kisses and stationary stars
still flying at the speed of light.
And over there out back
if you dig down through those
alabaster stoplights and those old 45's
you'll find a whole crate of second hand hope.
Yeah right there, that's no chrome,
you just gotta work, polish it up a little bit.
Most folks give up too easy,
trade it in for some injection mold
and here and now.

And over there across the freeway,
you see that purple awning flappin' in the breeze?
Well that's Momma Genuine's shop.
She's older than all of us put together
but she still laughs like a house.

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Now, she only sells tools but not like ya know,
she's got saws that put back together,
drills that make whole. Mommas a cool legend to know,
and she sells duct tape too.

And down there at the end of the block
are two kids, crew cut and pig tailed
sittin' behind a bindle top table
selling peanut-butter ice-cream out of a galvanized pale,
and there's no metaphor there it's just good ice-cream.
So here's what ya do, take a look around
pick out what reminds you of places you wanted to be
but gave up on going and jam it all in this big box called
"now".
Then go across the street to Momma Genuine's,
ask her how she's been , show her what I gave ya,
she'll know exactly what you need
and then go back in the center of that freeway
and get to work making it all fit.
You won't have any directions or factory number tabs
but don't panic,

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there's a hundred ways to do it right
and none to do it wrong cause your startin' out
with what's already been given up upon,
you can't do any worse.
Use the tools momma gave ya,
hum a little while ya work.
Then you find yourself sproutin' extra thumbs

Take a break.

Go around the block,
get yourself an ice cream.
Smile when they hand it to you,
tip 'em if you can
and when you get back it's all gonna make sense.
You'll see where it's gonna fit perfect
and where the duct tape has to go.
And when you get finished,
take whatever spare parts you got at the bottom of
"now"
and make yourself a little sign that says "tomorrow",

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and hang it on your masterpiece.
Then you go back down the block
to where those two kids are packing up
their peanut butter enterprise
cause somebody told them they'd fail
and I want you to hand them tomorrow.
Make sure they know how important it is.
After they've run off with it all elbows and smiles
y'all can come back here, we'll do it all over again.

Now I'm not telling you this to make a profit,
that's how so many good ideas go wrong.
I'm just tired of seeing every day people
screaming through these doors convinced
they're gonna hock even their littlest hopes and dreams
to fund their 401Ks.
I'm tired of seeing this whole world bet on going big
or giving up. Only handing out glory to newspaper
headlines
and story book endings, 'cause the truth is
I think we need those swing sets most on the rainy days.

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I'm happy going to sleep after just a goodnight kiss,
and I believe that beauty can be as simple as two kids,
crew cut and pig tails, handing me a scoop of peanut
butter ice cream
that's so good, you'd think it was a dream.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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